

Meet the Superhero Midwives Saving Lives in Colombia's Jungles

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What if you were about to have a baby, but the nearest hospital was days away? In parts of Colombia, thick jungles and rivers make it almost impossible to reach a doctor. That's where superheroes like Nohemí Manco step in. She's a traditional **midwife** a person trained to help moms give birth. Manco was only 14 when she delivered her first baby: her sister's! She wasn't scared because she'd watched her mom do it many times. Now 53, she's helped bring about 1,200 babies into the world. "When a baby starts coming, it feels like sunrise," she says. "Everything is dark, and then it's dawn." In Colombia, these midwives are called "**parteras tradicionales**." They are often the only **healthcare** for pregnant women in faraway villages. But many midwives say doctors and nurses have been mean to them. They've been laughed at or turned away from hospitals. "We felt the tradition was being lost because there was so much **discrimination**," says **midwife** Yuvianis Florez, 36. Still, the midwives don't hate **modern medicine**. They want to work together with doctors to keep moms and babies safe. A recent **survey** found over 1,700 traditional midwives in the region. But almost half are over 60, and many can't read. Manco hopes young people will learn the skills so this lifesaving tradition doesn't disappear.

Word Treasure

midwife -- A person who is trained to help women give birth, often in places without hospitals.

parteras tradicionales -- The Spanish phrase for traditional midwives, used in Colombia.

discrimination -- When people are treated unfairly or meanly because of who they are or what they do.

healthcare -- The care people need to stay healthy, like seeing a doctor or getting help when they are sick.

survey -- A study where people are asked questions to find out information about them.

modern medicine -- The way doctors and hospitals treat illness today, using science and technology.

Background you need

Colombia is a country in South America with thick jungles and rivers that make travel hard, especially for people in small villages.

For hundreds of years, traditional midwives have helped mothers give birth in places where doctors and hospitals are not nearby.

Nohemí Manco (a Colombian midwife who has delivered about 1,200 babies) learned from watching her own mother.

Break it down

WHO: Nohemí Manco, a traditional midwife in Colombia, and other midwives like Yuvianis Florez.

WHAT: These traditional midwives, called 'parteras tradicionales,' deliver babies in remote jungle areas where hospitals are hard to reach. They face discrimination from doctors but want to work with modern medicine.

WHERE: In the jungles and rivers of Colombia, especially in faraway villages.

WHY: Because many pregnant women can't get to hospitals, and the midwives' tradition is at risk as many are over 60 and can't read; young people need to learn these lifesaving skills.

Why it matters

This story shows that helping others doesn't always require a hospital or fancy tools--knowledge passed down in families can save lives, and everyone deserves respect for their skills.

Test what you remember

1. Who is Nohemí Manco?

- ☐ (A) A traditional midwife
- ☐ (B) A jungle explorer
- ☐ (C) A nurse at a big hospital
- ☐ (D) A pilot who flies to villages

2. About how many babies has Nohemí Manco helped deliver?

- ☐ (A) 500
- ☐ (B) 1,200
- ☐ (C) 2,000
- ☐ (D) 100

3. What do people in Colombia call traditional midwives?

- ☐ (A) Doctoras naturales
- ☐ (B) Parteras tradicionales
- ☐ (C) Enfermeras de selva
- ☐ (D) Curanderas

4. Why do many midwives feel their tradition is in danger?

- ☐ (A) They don't like modern medicine
- ☐ (B) There are no more pregnant women
- ☐ (C) They have been laughed at or turned away by doctors
- ☐ (D) The jungles are disappearing

5. What did the recent survey find about traditional midwives in the region?

- ☐ (A) Most of them are under 30
- ☐ (B) Almost half are over 60 and many can't read
- ☐ (C) They all live in big cities
- ☐ (D) None of them want to work with doctors

6. What does Nohemí Manco hope will happen?

- ☐ (A) Young people will learn midwifery skills
- ☐ (B) The government will build more hospitals
- ☐ (C) She will retire soon
- ☐ (D) All midwives will become doctors

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Midwives:** They feel proud of their hundreds of years of knowledge and want doctors to treat them as equals. They believe combining old and new methods is best.
2. **Doctors and Nurses:** Some have been mean to midwives, maybe because they worry about safety without modern tools. They might not trust traditional birth methods.
3. **Young People in Colombia:** They could learn midwifery skills to keep the tradition alive and help their communities, especially since many older midwives cannot read or write.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):